# Duolingo

Language Learning platform

# Problem Statement

**Build out a new feature in Duolingo where people can augment their learning with real people on top of the automated learning tracks.**

**The problem statement seems pretty interesting. However, to make it more specific and measurable, I paraphrased the hypothesis as:**

***“Design a new feature in Duolingo that provides collaborative learning experience and improves user engagement”***

# Target customers

- Users planning to go abroad and pursue any foreign course
- People wanting to augment their learning about already learnt foreign languages
- School kids using Duolingo to learn foreign languages which are a part of curriculum
- Users passionate about learning new cultures
- Users wanting to learn languages for Brain training
- Teachers teaching foreign languages in institutes

# Competitor Analysis

| Product \| Aspect | DuoLingo | HelloTalk | Drops | MemRise |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **User Base** | 500mn | 30mn + | ~30mn | 55mn |
| **Usability** | Simple UI having a sequential process of learning. Very easy to use | Lots of features on how/what to learn. However, usage is complex. | Easy to learn process (Similar to Duolingo). Option to choose topics e.g. Food, Travel | Vey simple app with performance streak highlights on the home page itself. |
| **Onboarding** | Registration with simple questions on current proficiency levels and goals | Easy sign in process | Onboarding process includes quick instructions on app useability | Onboarding with an option to choose current level of proficiency |
| **Platforms** | Web & Mobile app (Android & Appstore) | Web & Mobile app (Android & Appstore) | Web Mobil app (Android & App store) | Web Mobile (Android & App store) |
| **Integration** | Gmail, WhatsApp, In app notifications | SIMILAR | SIMILAR | SIMILAR |
| **Flexibility to choose modules** | Low | Medium-High | High | Low |
| **UI/UX perspective** | Minimalistic, easy to use | Cluttered owing to high number of features | Simple UI However the app's bright color scheme received mixed feedbacks | Decent UI with a color scheme similar to Duolingo |
| **Functionalities** | Leaderboard, Forum, Podcasts, Events etc. | Chat messenger, Detailed community forum, Personalized sessions | Language learning (Topic wise) | Language learning (additional features lacking) |
| **Overall quality** |  |  |  |  |

# Customer Discovery

# Survey - Link to the survey form

- ***No. of people surveyed:*** 16
- ***Target audience:*** Students, Working Professionals
- ***Source of participants:*** Friends, family

# Interview

- ***No. of people interviewed: 5***
- ***Target audience:*** Working Professionals
- ***Source of participants:*** Friends and family

- ***Areas of focus:***
  - ***Objective of learning foreign languages***
  - ***Difference between Online vs offline mode of learning***
  - ***Challenges faced while learning from Duolingo***

# Insights from the Survey

Main reasons for learning a foreign language were Travel, culture and Brain Training.

**80%** of the users have had experience of learning basics of a foreign language from school/offline institutes. Further, they decided to enhance their learning experience via online mode and adopted Duolingo

Only 1 out of 5 users had used competitor apps as well like HelloTalk and Memrise apart from Duolingo.

**More than 75%** of the users were using free version of the application

**4 out of 5 users** felt the application as a supplementary source (not primary) of learning. They used it for average of 15-20 mins on a daily basis for some time to maintain streak but eventually left it due to limited and isolated learning experience. Some critical challenges faced while learning from the application:

1) Isolated learning experience. Even if there is an ability for collaborative learning in apps like HelloTalk, the experience is cluttered
2) No individual Mentor guidance resulting in an inability to get the feedback
3) Applications are not designed to teach language fundamentals and grammar rules from scratch
4) Inability to access different modules freely in apps like Duolingo.
5) Lack of knowledge about culture/day-to-day happenings/facts related to the language in the application

As mentioned, **80% of the users** used Duolingo to polish already learnt foreign language from school or institutes. While improving on the already learnt language, they started using Duolingo to learnt some different language from scratch. However, due to lack of basic structure and lack of collaborative experience, they didn't continue and dropped.

Also, more than 50% of the users were willing to go for the paid plan if these challenges were solved.

# User Personas

**Name**
*Aastha Sharad*

**Description**
Aastha is a working professional in IT sector and has a passion to explore new culture and experiences. She likes learning new languages and has completed her advanced level grade certification in German and basic level certification in Spanish.

**One liner Description:**
She has a goal to learn 4 foreign languages in next 3 years.

**Demographic Information**
Age: 28
Gender: Female
Technical comfort: High
City: Tier 1
Foreign Languages learnt: German, Spanish
Frequency of using language learning app: 15-20 mins per day

**Language learning goal:**
Aastha's journey in German started during her junior college as a part of school curriculum. She learnt the basics of German during her school days. Later, she decided to polish her German skills and joined an offline institute. She used Duolingo as a supplementary app every night for 15-20 mins as she was intrigued by the Gamified approach. She completed multiple level checkpoints and topped the leader dashboard many times. Once she had the grasp, she decided to dwell into Spanish as well, solely from Duolingo. However, she realized the app is not comprehensive enough to impart the basic knowledge and there was no way to gain feedbacks. She even tried a couple of other apps and later on decided to join a crash course from an offline institute.

**Challenges:**
No feedback mechanism
Lack of two way communication
Content not comprehensive enough

**Name**
*Krutika Ramchandani*

**Description**
Krutika is a working professional in BFSI sector and also a German language teacher. She likes learning new languages and has completed her advanced level grade certification in German and Italian.

**One liner Description:**
She keeps on adding her learning portfolio of foreign languages and even participates in foreign cultural events

**Demographic Information**
Age: 27
Gender: Female
Technical comfort: High
City: Tier 1
Foreign Languages learnt: German, Italian
Frequency of using language learning app: 30 mins per day

**Language learning goal:**
Krutika's journey in German also started during her junior college as apart of their school curriculum. She learnt the basics of German during her school days. Later, she decided to polish her German skills and joined an offline institute. She used Duolingo as a supplementary app every night for 30 mins. She often used Hellotalk and Memrise to connect with fellow learners. She even purchased Duolingo paid plan for six months but didn't continue. Later on she purchased a book to continue her language journey

**Challenges:**
Dearth of structured document
lack of interactive feedback or human support
Limited to providing basic knowledge
Lot of repetition
Phrases used are not common

# Key Product Features

# DUOLINGO

| Problem | Solution/Feature |
|---|---|
| Lack of Collaborative learning Experience resulting in lack of motivation | Gang Leaderboard: Users can create a small group and based on their collaborative efforts as a group win rewards on achieving different milestones ( Experience points, Lingots)<br><br>Language competitions: Multiple case study competitions to be listed on the app giving users an opportunity to participate alone or in groups and win exciting prizes |
| No individual Mentor guidance resulting in an inability to get the feedback | Provision to assign mentors who have achieved higher proficiency level to have weekly interactions with participants via chat or community forums |
| Not designed to teach language fundamentals and grammar rules from scratch | Although, the content will become better and better with time. However, conduct more events related to Grammar learning and promote them via different ways. Also, addition of documented content comprising basic grammar rules can be done. |
| Inability to access modules from different domains freely in Duolingo | Unlocking few modules from each domain in case a person wants to learn about specific domain(like travel) only(& not all domains) |

# Problem Validation with feedback and company's mission

Based on our problem statement, company's mission and validation from user research, the problem of lack of collaborative learning experience should be taken first. Probable solutions are:

**Gang Leaderboard:** Users can create a small group and based on their collaborative efforts as a group win rewards on achieving different milestones ( Experience points, Lingots) and a Gang Leader board will be created

**Language competitions:** Multiple case study  competitions to be listed on the app giving users an opportunity to participate alone or in groups and win exciting prizes

**Group streak**: A consistent practice along with friends will help create a streak resulting in higher motivation and rewards

**Chat messenger:** Learn the language while you chat with your friends(and gets translations suggestions for phrases) within the app.

# MVP Features-

## Gang Leaderboard:

In MVP, we decide to launch the following feature in Phase 1 for Mobile users
Total Duolingo user Base: 500 million
Monthly active user Base: 52 million
Type of users : Basic level user | Intermediate level user | Advanced level user
Standard Mobile to desktop traffic ratio : 70:30
Mobile MAU : 35 million

- For basic level users, there will be an option to create groups. Discovery of User Group icon can be from profile page or a separate icon for creating Groups on home page can be given. Post click of that, Users can provide a Group name and add members(who follow them). A group dashboard will be shown displaying basic profile details of each user and individual streaks/Lingots/Experience points and overall Group Metrics.
- Post completion of certain levels and achieving overall Group Experience points/Streaks, Group will be rewarded with more Lingots/Hearts that they can reuse to unlock levels. There will be basic chat functionality for Group users to coordinate amongst themselves and create task threads.

**Note:** This can be launched as a POC in specific countries(US, Japan, Germany) or for top learning languages. Once we receive enough traction, then we can expand to manage to broader level data.

## Next Iteration

Once we realize that this feature is being used, next phase iteration can be creation of Gang Leaderboard apart from Individual Leaderboard and ranking Groups based on their metrics achievement(Gang streak, Lingots)

## Next Phase iteration:

Language competitions: Multiple case study  competitions to be listed on the app giving users an opportunity to participate alone or in groups and win exciting prizes
This can be added along with Events section where users can participate in Groups. We can collaborate with institutes and teachers across the world who can list out various competitions. Basic registration fees to participate in those competition and winners will be rewarded.

## Chat feature:

Later on we can also work on creation of entire chatbot functionality. Users can chat with their friends(whom they follow) and engage in conversations. People will also see translation/correction suggestions for the phrases while they are interacting. Users can also see people(not gender) in their nearby region who are also learning similar languages and connect with them.

## Mock ups

Have created few basic mock ups(due to limited time) to depict the discovery point of Gang Leader board and further journey:
Gang Leader board: guigDkCNk1LVbthTumWAjv.png (1658×730) (balsamiq.com)
One to one chat: ce8gYBvba4mAywBdp8mYrj.png (1253×725) (balsamiq.com)

**Note:** If more time in hand, could have gone into detailed aspects of the following:

- Detailed User journey of the feature
- Detailed mock-ups depicting user journey

## Metrics to track

- No. of Groups created
- Active users base
- CTR for Group Dashboard and Group competitions
- Churn Rate
- Streak Rate
- Avg. time spent per user on app

# Thank You